Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "To Nature"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Coleridge's poem include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
couplet,
didacticism,
enjambment,
esemplastic power,
imagery (olfactory, visual),
imagination,
inversion,
metaphor,
muse,
near rhyme,
pantheism,
polysyndeton,
run-on,
sonnet,
tone, and
volta.

The student might recognize in the title and in the last three lines that Coleridge's sonnet is an apostrophe, one in which the poet presents a pantheistic view of the universe, one in which the poet offers, as sacrifice (line 14), his poem to inspirational nature. The contestant might spot the didacticism in nature's offering both "Lessons of love" and examples of "earnest Piety" (line 5). Nature in her role as muse is welcomed by the poet who, in the presence of "all created things," will build an "altar in the fields" so that he may thank her.

The young writer might also recognize the conditional structure of the sonnet's argument: "It may indeed be phantasy" and "So let it be" (lines 1 and 6), as well as "and if the wide world rings / In mock of this belief," then the poet will not be troubled (lines 6-8).

The contestant might choose to focus on the "sweet fragrance" of the poet's sacrifice, his drawing from nature (the esemplastic power, the creative aspect of the poet's imagination) the beauty that becomes the imagery of his poetic expression: this very sonnet, his apostrophe addressed to the immediate source of his inspiration, nature.